

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 14



CHAPTER 14



NINETEEN GUNS

David — and his crew — all died of fever! Heartsick, Nat hurried to Mary's house. All the way there his thoughts were a jumble. What could he say to Mary? How could he comfort her?

"Maybe if I waited till after supper," he muttered, "I could think of something to say." But he knew he was being a coward to tell himself that. He reached the house, tapped, and opened the door.

Lois was there with Mary, helping Mary's little daughter read her *New England Primer*.

Mary saw Nat first. "Nat!" She came to meet him. "Dear Nat!" Her lips trembled and her eyes filled with tears. For a moment she leaned her forehead against his shoulder, hiding her face. "If it hadn't been for you, Nat, I wouldn't have married David."

"I know," Nat admitted miserably. He'd been thinking of that, himself.

"Did Dr. Bentley tell you I wanted to see you?"

"Yes, Mary. I came right away."

"I wanted to say *thank you*, Nat. If it hadn't been for you, I would have missed being the happiest woman in Salem — while David was here." She lifted her head. Her lips were steady now; she smiled slightly. "Thank you, Nat. And now . . . will you do something for me?"

"Anything I can."

"Sit down here, and tell us all about your voyage — everything — just as David used to when he came home."

Three hours later, supper was over, the dishes washed, and Nat was still talking. Someone called, the door opened, and Elizabeth Boardman came in with her cousin, Mary Ingersoll, whom all the family called Polly.

Elizabeth's violet eyes glowed. "I heard you were here!"

Polly's level brown eyes danced with mischief. "I think Elizabeth was just going to drop in to see Mary — and pretend to be surprised when she saw you — but she was afraid I'd tell on her!"

Elizabeth blushed and laughed. "Children!" she said.

Polly made a face. "You're not so old! Sixteen! And I'm almost!"

Elizabeth laughed with Polly. She said, "Tell us all about everything, Nat!"

Nat was solemn. "I couldn't possibly. It's taken me three hours to tell Mary and Lois — and I haven't got them off Bourbon yet. Little girls shouldn't stay up that late."

This time Polly made a face at him. "When Father comes home, I stay up till all hours!" Nat could imagine that. Polly's father was Captain Ingersoll, one of the most famous captains who sailed a Derby ship.

He told them about Bourbon, and Captain Blanchard's *Vive la république*. At nine, he walked to the Boardman house with them, and then went to see Dr. Bentley.

Dr. Bentley talked late, bringing Nat up to date on the news of nations. Nat listened hungrily. He remembered how Hab had once said, "When I get home from a voyage, I feel as though I had been asleep six months."

Affairs were in a miserable tangle, Dr. Bentley said. Things weren't settled with England yet. Americans were still fighting the Jay Treaty bitterly. English captains were still searching our vessels and seizing our sailors. And the trouble with France grew more serious every day. "I doubt if you'll be sailing soon again, Nat. At least not until the trouble with France is settled."

But a few days later Mr. Derby called Nat and Captain Prince to his office to talk over another voyage. "The ship is named the *Astrea*." He smiled slightly. "I rather like that name."

Nat thought of the earlier *Astrea*, on which Captain John Derby had brought the news of peace from Paris. He remembered how proud he'd been when his father said, "Crowded sail, he did, and came from Paris in twenty-two days!"

Mr. Derby seemed to be reading Nat's thoughts. "The other *Astrea* made a record for herself. I intend that this *Astrea* shall set a record, too; the first Salem ship ever to enter Manila Harbor!"

Manila! Halfway around the world! Evidently, Nat decided, Mr. Derby wasn't too concerned about the trouble with France.

Mr. Derby went on in his quiet way. "The *Astrea* mounts nineteen guns, Captain Prince. If any of your crew has ever shipped on a privateer or a letter of marque ship they — ah — might be useful."

Nat's scalp prickled.

Captain Prince merely nodded. "Any ports before Manila?"

“Yes. You’ll carry a mixed cargo to Lisbon, and stop at Funchal, in the Madeira Islands. Then on to Manila.”

When Nat and Captain Prince left the office, Nat said, “Manila . . . I wonder what language they talk there?”

“The Spanish are the . . . ” Prince stared at Nat. “Don’t tell me you’re going to learn another language?”

“Why not . . . sir?”

Prince pursed his lips and shook his head. “Carry on, Mr. Bowditch.”

A few days later Nat was ready to start learning Spanish; he had a dictionary, a grammar, and a New Testament. He opened the New Testament to the first chapter of John. Again he repeated the words in English: In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God and the Word was God. He looked at the Spanish: *En el principio era el Verbo, y el Verbo era con Dios, y el Verbo era Dios.* Nat smiled. Spanish, he decided, would be the easiest language of all to learn. He could figure out every word in the sentence without a bit of trouble.

Toward the last of March Mary said, "Do you have to sail Friday, Nat?"

Nat teased her. "You're not superstitious about Friday, are you?"

"Saturday's your birthday. If you do have to sail Friday, I wish —"

Nat saw the idea back of Mary's eyes. "Oh, no! You don't tell anyone that Saturday is my birthday!"

"Why not?"

"I wouldn't care for a celebration on shipboard."

"Why? What would they do?"

"Oh — something jolly — like ducking me or pouring a few buckets of water on me. No celebrations, please!"

Mary promised she'd keep his birthday a dark secret. Nat kissed her and went down to the wharf to see how the loading of the *Astrea* was coming along.

Mr. Collins was on board, and in a foul humor. "You and your teaching!" he growled.

"What's wrong with my teaching?"

"We've lost four of the men we were counting on — including Keeler!"

Nat grinned. "Keeler was supposed to be a trouble-maker, wasn't he? I'd think you'd be relieved."

"He was," Collins growled, "but Keeler knew guns. Blast you and your teaching! Four good men all signed up as second mates on smaller vessels!"

"Good for them!"

Collins glared. "What about us?"

"We'll just have to replace them."

"Sure. Just like that. And do you know who is going to replace Keeler? Lem Harvey!"

Nat whistled. He knew Lem Harvey — a huge fellow with hulking shoulders and a sullen, swarthy face. A troublemaker if ever one lived. "Why sign him on?"

"Because," Collins growled, "he sailed on privateers before he was knee high to a capstan. He knows guns. If we have trouble with the French he'll be worth the rest of the crew put together."

"And if we don't have trouble with the French?" Nat asked.

"We'll have trouble with Lem. Personally, I'd rather have trouble with the French!"

A boy came aboard with a letter for Nat.

Dear Nat

Good luck on your voyage. When the *Astrea* sails, I'm going to be on the captain's walk, watching you.

ELIZABETH

Early Friday morning Nat strolled across the Common toward the big white house and saw Elizabeth standing on the captain's walk. She waved and signaled that she'd come down. A few moments later she came outside to meet him.

"You're shivering," Nat said. "You're cold."

"I'm not cold," she whispered, "I'm scared!" Her violet eyes looked bigger than ever in her heart-shaped face. "Nat, they have *guns* on the *Astrea*! Why?"

"Just so we won't have any trouble. If a French privateer sees us, we'll look so dangerous the privateer will crowd sail and run!"

Elizabeth didn't smile. "Nat, please take care of yourself. If you — if anything — " Suddenly she stood on tiptoe, kissed him, wheeled, and fled into the house.

Nat stared after her. He started to follow. He stopped. Nonsense, he told himself. She's just a child. Get on board your ship, Mr. Bowditch! He strode briskly toward the waterfront.

Somehow — he didn't quite know how it happened — he found himself on Union Wharf instead of Derby, and had to pretend he was looking for someone.

Once the *Astrea* had weighed anchor, though, he forgot about everything behind him. He even forgot about sixteen-year-olds who did unexpected things — such as kissing a man good-by. For the wind was against them. If the *Astrea* managed to beat out of Salem Harbor, every man on board was going to need four arms and six pairs of hands to handle sail.

The men worked desperately to keep her far enough into the wind to clear Naugus Head. But they couldn't make it. They had to come to and anchor again. All day Friday and Friday night, they stood their watches and slept with their ears cocked; all day Saturday and all that night and all Sunday morning they waited. It was late Sunday afternoon before they finally got under way.

Again they divided the men into watches.

When Nat had his first choice, he heard himself say, "Lem Harvey!" And then wondered why he did it. Was it because he felt responsible for Lem's being on the *Astrea*?

When the watches were divided, Captain Prince stood on the quarter-deck and spoke to the crew. If anything, he sounded grimmer than he had sounded on the *Henry*. He added something to what he had said then: "There are two things every man of you must learn and learn fast. First, you'll learn to recognize the colors of every

nation. When you're on lookout and you sight a sail, you'll take it for granted it's an enemy until you know it's a friend. Second, you must learn to handle these guns like the crew of a man-o'-war. Lem Harvey, I'm putting you in charge of training the crew on the guns. I want these men drilled until they can cast loose their guns, run them out, and fire — " he snapped his fingers — "like that! Do you understand?"

Lem Harvey didn't smile, or straighten, or show any pleasure. He scowled, his heavy black brows coming together over his sullen eyes. "Aye, aye, sir. They'll learn . . . " That was all he said aloud. But Nat saw his mouth finish the sentence. "They'll learn, or they'll wish they had!"

Day after day Nat heard Lem roar his orders and bel-
low his abuse. Between spates of profanity, the directions
were exact:

“CAST LOOSE YOUR GUNS! No! You thumb-
fingered fool! Make that muzzle lashing fast to the eye-
bolt!

“LEVEL YOUR GUNS! How many times do I have
to tell you — lash that bed to the bolts!

“TAKE OUT YOUR TOMPIONS! You blasted
fool! Don't stand there and hold it! Drop it! What you
think that lanyard's for?

“RUN OUT YOUR GUNS! You! Look at those
tackle falls! What sort of lubber's coil is that? In fakes,
I told you! In fakes!

“PRIME! Get that powder horn out of the way! Serve you right if I’d let you stand there till it blew up in your face! Move!

“POINT YOUR GUNS! No! First with your side sights, and then with your upper sights! You there, ready with that match!

“FIRE!”

And the guns roared. Before the sound died and the smoke lifted, Lem was bellowing again.

“SPONGE YOUR GUNS! Where the . . . is that sponge! Ram it down! Ram it home! Twist it! You want to leave a spark in there to blow you to . . . Ready with that cartridge! What are you doing? Sleeping on your feet?

"LOAD! Get that wad in there, you fool! Ram it home! Ram it!

"SHOT YOUR GUNS!"

Day after day Lem bullied and jeered and cursed the men. But they learned to handle the guns. They finally moved fast enough to please even Captain Prince. But Lem still bullied them. When the men weren't drilling on the guns, they were slaving in the rigging.

Nat was glad for the crew when they sighted the coast of Portugal. They stood off and on all night. In the morning, a pilot came on board to take them up the Tagus River. They sailed through the mile-wide mouth of the river, and then saw the Tagus spread into a great bay. On the north bank of the river the city of Lisbon rose on the hills.

Nat stared at the houses; he'd never seen anything like them — tile roofed, and painted every color of the rainbow.

Mr. Collins drawled, "Well, Mr. Bowditch, did you learn Portygee talk, too? So you could be handy in port?"

Nat said, "Blast! I didn't think of that. I've been learning Spanish — for Manila."

But when Nat and Captain Prince went on shore, they found the custom officials conducted all their business in French. Again Captain Prince clapped his hand on Nat's shoulder and said, "We don't need an interpreter!" Soon Nat was busy changing *escudos* to dollars, and adding figures in his head before the other men could add them on paper. Betweentimes he went sightseeing in Lisbon.

I must remember all this, he thought, to tell Elizabeth when I . . . He felt his cheeks get hot. To tell all of them, I mean.

But it was Elizabeth's face, and her sparkling eyes, he could see when he thought of home. He drew rough sketches of things he wanted to remember — the tawny oxen that looked so fierce — with their six-foot spread of horns; the amazing women of Portugal, who carried everything on their heads — boxes, baskets, and huge flat trays of fish. He tried to sketch the streets of Lisbon, but he couldn't get the effect he wanted on flat paper.

I'll tell her — them — he thought, that no matter where I wanted to go, it was always uphill from where I'd been. He could imagine how Elizabeth's eyes would sparkle. "When we get back," he said . . . and he stopped.

Before they got back, the *Astrea* would have sailed halfway around the world. Lisbon might seem far from Salem now, but it was next door to home, compared to far-off Manila.

He found an old sailor who had doubled the Cape, and been to India and through Sunda Strait to Manila. With the help of a map, gestures, Spanish, and figures, Nat managed to learn a lot.

Things went quickly in Lisbon — but not quickly

enough to keep Lem from slipping ashore when he was on duty, getting into a fight, and landing in jail. He was put in the brig until the *Astrea* was ready to sail. The morning they were to weigh anchor he was released.

A storm howled in from the Atlantic, and for a week they waited out miserable days and nights. Lem tried to slip ashore again, and sat out the rest of the storm in the brig.

After a week, they managed to beat out of the Tagus, into the Atlantic. Then they battled head winds to Madeira. Lem was released from the brig again; they needed his weight on the halyards.

At last they anchored in Funchal Bay. The storm had ended; a moon rose, and they saw the whitewashed houses rising on steep hills, gleaming in the moonlight.

When Captain Prince and Nat went ashore, the first man to greet them was Mr. Pintard, the American consul. He hailed them like long-lost brothers, asked news of home, and invited them to dinner, all in one breath.

Mrs. Pintard was all smiles, too, when they dined in the Pintard home. She was full of stories of the islands. "Mr. Bowditch," she said, "have you heard that delightful legend of how Machico got its name? There were two lovers — "

Mr. Pintard smiled. "My dear, Mr. Bowditch is a mathematician, not a — Well, he'd hardly be interested in your legends."

"A mathematician? Then here's an interesting problem for you, Mr. Bowditch. Five years ago, I inherited some money in Ireland." She named the amount.

Mr. Pintard said, "Dear, wait until after dinner, and we'll let Mr. Bowditch write down — "

Nat said, "And what happened?"

"The money was invested in Ireland at eight per cent," she told him. "After three years the whole sum — interest and all — was sent to England. It was invested there at eight and a half per cent. After two years — let me see — yes, two years and two months — the whole sum was sent to me here. How much should I have received?"

Mr. Pintard said, "After dinner, dear, you can write down the whole thing for him, and he can take it home and work it out. We don't want him to waste his evening over figures, do we?"

Nat laid down his knife and fork and sat staring at the flickering lights of the candles. After a little he said, "Eight hundred and forty-three pounds, fifteen shillings, and six and one-fourth pence. Tell me about Machico."

Mrs. Pintard stared.

Mr. Pintard said, "What!"

"Machico," Nat repeated. "I'd like to hear how it got its name."

Captain Prince grinned. "Two minutes by my watch. He won't have to waste the evening after all."

"But that's right!" Mrs. Pintard gasped. "To the last fraction! That's exactly how much I received!"

"Of course," Nat told her. "That's the beauty of mathematics. It's exact. Now, about Machico . . ."

Mrs. Pintard was still staring at him, dumfounded.

"You've no idea how handy he is in port." Captain Prince was amused.

Mr. Pintard shook his head slowly. Then he said, "I guess I'll have to tell you the legend; my wife is too dumfounded to talk. About Machico — it was this way: it seems there were two lovers, Robert Machim and Anna

d'Arfet. Some sort of Romeo-and-Juliet mix-up between their families, I suppose. Anyhow, they were fleeing from England to France. Their ship was caught in a storm and driven clear to the Madeiras. The place they were driven ashore was named *Machico* after them. I never heard whether they lived happily ever after, or were wrecked. But that's the legend."

Nat said, "Thank you. I'll tell her about it when I — " He felt his ears getting red. "My sister, I mean. She's always interested to hear about everything."

Mrs. Pintard was still dazed. "To the last fraction of —" Then, womanlike, she must have noticed Nat's flush. Her eyes danced. "Mr. Bowditch! You're sure it's your sister?"

"Are you trying to arrange a romance for my super-cargo?" Captain Prince asked.

Nat laughed with them. He knew he might as well. A fine chance he'd have to make a girl fall in love with him. What was it Lizza had said to him once? "*You mathematician!* I wish you could at least pay compliments without arithmetic!"